Nayanthara, 39
Actress-film producer-entrepreneur

Crossover Star



ACCOMPLISHMENT
For playing by her own rules, ruling the box office and headlining scripts without strong male heroes in the South

A TAMIL CINEMA STAR with films in all the South languages (and a Hindi debut in 2023), Nayanthara is an actress who believes in keeping her personal space separate from her public persona. Spotting the 'Lady Superstar', as she's known, in public or seeing her give interviews is rare. Even her film promotions are somewhat muted. Her 2023 film, the Shahrukh-starrer *Jawan*, was her Bollywood debut, but she was not present in Chennai for the audio launch or at the 'success party' in Mumbai. She did make a speech in a pre-recorded video, though.

December 2023 marks 20 years in acting for Nayanthara, who was born Diana Mariam Kurian. Though she got the breaks (and hits) early on, it was around 2014-15 that she struck gold, headlining films like *Anaamika* and *Maya*, with the latter becoming a superhit. Rarely has a female star led critical and commercial success in a Tamil film the way Nayanthara did with *Maya*.

Soon, filmmakers were either going to her with scripts written exclusively for her—*Dora*, *Aramm* and *Kolamavu Kokila*— or those that revolve around her character, like *Naanum Rowdy Dhan* and *Imaikka Nodigal*. In the past year, she's already had two projects of her own—*Connect* and *Annapoorani*.

It's been a thorny road too. Right from her early years in the industry, Nayanthara's personal life has been under the scrutiny of an unscrupulous local media. During the trailer launch of her film *Kolaiyuthir Kaalam*, actor Radha Ravi spoke disparagingly of Nayanthara while raking in the applause from the audience. A day later, Nayanthara issued a statement condemning the remarks, and asking the Nadigar Sangam (Actors' Association) when they plan to constitute an internal complaints committee. Nayanthara continues to brave them all and prefers to be a recluse, but then who can blame her? ■

–Aditya Shrikrishna

BEHIND THE SCENES

↘ INSTA DEBUT
Known to be extremely private, she joined Instagram ahead of the trailer launch of *Jawan* with a video of her with her twin sons, Uyir and Ulagam. It gained one million followers in record time

↘ PRODUCER HAT
Nayanthara and husband Vignesh Shivan have their own production company, Rowdy Pictures. *Koozhangal* (Pebbles), one of their films, was India's entry for the Best International Feature at the 2022 Oscars